

Situation Ethics is a helpful method of moral decision making

Fletcher's teleological theory, situation ethics, is primarily premised on agape, the founding pillar of Christianity. The importance of selfless love is drawn from Jesus regarding 'the greatest commandment' as 'love your neighbour as yourself,' (Mark 12:28-31) and Fletcher defines a moral decision as acting in alignment with love, empathy and mutual sacrifice. Attempting to marry legalism: the view that people require fixed rules to follow, and antinomianism: the abandonment of laws or rules, Fletcher saw his theory as a middle ground. Situation ethics would succeed by giving clear guidance to adhere to the law of love and by considering morally pertinent contextual factors of a specific situation without being overly binding nor retreat into moral chaos. In order to explain the content of morality in Situation ethics, defining what love is and how it should influence moral judgements, Fletcher introduced the six fundamental propositions. This entailed that only love is intrinsically good and should be the ruling norm of Christian decision, love and justice are the same, love wills the neighbour's good, only the end justifies the means, and lastly love's decisions are made situationally. Furthermore, in order to use the moral theory in real situations as a method, Fletcher derived the four working principles: pragmatism, entailing that an action must work in practice to achieve love, relativism, where rules are not absolute, positivism, detailing our choice to believe in love as the highest good, and finally, personalism, suggesting the prioritisation of people over laws. Situation ethics is premised on human 'conscience' which is seen by Fletcher as a verb, not a noun, departing from the Christian notion that it is an internal faculty or moral compass, and instead, defined as an active ability for individuals to determine the requirements of agape in a situation. As a result, through building a framework of principles to define love, and through constructing a process of how love should be applied, with correct use of our conscience, Fletcher contended that this would offer a helpful method for moral decision making.

Firstly, one might put forward that situation ethics is not a helpful method for decision making as it goes against an individual's moral intuition and therefore presents an unnatural view of our human nature. In Fletcher's eyes, the 'good' is seen through a prescriptive lens, and entails performing actions which exemplify agape, therefore his moral framework is entirely premised on humans being able to act selflessly. However, from a scientific perspective, it can be convincingly shown that although humans might have the propositional knowledge of what will be the most loving act, due to their intrinsic nature, they may lack the ability to act altruistically.

In alignment with Dawkins, shown through evolutionary biology, humans are born with the notion of a 'selfish gene' which demonstrates that we have a drive for our own survival and reproduction, hence our actions will be in adherence with our self-preservation. This suggests that self-love is an essential, undetachable element of a human and a prerequisite for our flourishing as a species. This makes it impossible to conceive of a world in which humans act wholly selflessly, given empirical evidence that demonstrates our DNA is encoded with the permanent disposition for selfish actions. While Fletcher associates our desire to fulfil our self-interest with immorality, Dawkins would detail how selfishness can be used as an advantage for survival. In application to moral decision-making, situation ethics can therefore be challenged fatefully on two distinct grounds: firstly, that an agent is not able to act selflessly all the time as we cannot abstract from our biological self, and secondly, that acting selfishly is not intrinsically immoral but crucial for the continuation of our human race.

In order to respond to this challenge, we can appeal to Hume's Law whereby he establishes that one cannot logically derive an "ought" (a normative moral claim) from a factual "is" statement, as describing what is the case does not lend itself to prescribing what ought to be. Therefore, simply by science, if it demonstrates that humans are naturally selfish, it does not entail that we ought to act selfishly according to our nature. To agree with the latter would be to obtain the view that morality must necessarily be built into reality. Yet, Hume argues that moral values are not observable or factual as they cannot be seen, measured or tested in the same way that objective facts can be, and so the fact of us being selfish cannot form a moral absolutist principle that commands our actions should be in alignment with our nature.

However, while this may challenge the second basis which justifies natural human tendencies to be selfish as not strictly immoral, it does not provide a convincing attack of the first basis. This is because Hume's Law relies on the assumption that we have the ability to override our selfish desires, regardless if they are immoral or not. However, there might be a critical gap between knowledge and action, of which Hume would fail to account for. Since decision making entails action, it would seem that the existence of the selfish gene within humans provides a barrier that prevents individuals from acting according to their moral knowledge.

Finally, Fletcher might respond and argue that to deconstruct this barrier one must use their conscience which would allow individuals to make moral decisions which are altruistic. Conscience could be used as a practical tool for applying agape to moral problems, allowing one to calculate or decide the most loving course of action. Consequently, the 'selfish gene' ultimately provides an anodyne objection, where even if we were to regard it as true that humans are innately

selfish, through the active process of conscience we could override this desire and the framework could still be functional for moral decision making.

Secondly, situation ethics suffers from a fundamental tension: Fletcher deems love as both an 'attitude' or motivator for moral action, and as an end goal to produce the most loving outcome. The main problem arises in Fletcher's presupposition that possessing the attitude of love will necessarily entail that one accomplishes the most loving consequence. However, this is ultimately flawed as love is not a prerequisite for the most loving outcome, nor does the most loving outcome have to be motivated by love. When applied to ethical decision making, it seems that love does not need to be the fuel for moral outcomes, and therefore Fletcher's framework collapses.

This can be better understood through an example: an agent acts out of selfless love when he sees a drowning man in a river, and decides to jump into the river in order to save the man, who survives. Later, the same man shoots fifty innocent people in a terrorist killing. While it would appear that the agent's decision to save the man was in alignment with the primary principle of agape, it seems to not yield the most loving outcome, and therefore would seem morally obscure. This questions the temporal boundaries constituting the duration of a situation and how far into the future we must consider the consequences, which Fletcher fails to address. There is an absent framework for where a situation begins or ends, as it is uncertain what is morally pertinent in a situation, and if the most loving outcome is in the immediate, short-term implications or in the long-term consequences. Either way, both face the same teleological problem of calculation, where to decide the most moral action seems to require an epistemic demand that humans are bereft of as we lack the ability to foresee the future. As Anscombe would regard prescriptivity as a necessary condition for moral decision making, due to the failure of situation ethics in providing us with moral knowledge and its contingency on consequences, it could be regarded as unhelpful.

Therefore, on the grounds that Fletcher's ethics are built on the assumption that if one acts out of love it will produce the most loving outcome, it can be rendered unhelpful as a theory for decision making.